one member of Team Rahul whom I met on a couple of occasions was Kanishka Singh. A slight, bespectacled, soft-spoken young man, he was the son of a former foreign secretary, S.K. Singh, who later became a governor. Kanishka had a degree in international studies and business from the University of Pennsylvania, a degree in economics from St Stephens College and had even done a stint in an investment bank in New York. In other words, he was the perfect child of Delhi's elite Lutyensland, complete with well-connected parents, a foreign degree and a CV that would probably have got him a top job in corporate India. But was he the right man to be strategizing politics for the Congress's future?

Kanishka had, interestingly, written about the need to restructure the political system in an article in *Seminar* magazine in December 2005: 'Our leaders are older than they ought to be. Our citizenry is young. A severe and visible disconnect exists between the separate time horizons that each of the two groups are focused on and invested in . . . If India is to leapfrog into the millennium we live in, we need to be proactive in demonstrating that political and organizational capital is being invested in the domain of future-oriented implementation.' The words sounded perfect, echoing Rahul Gandhi's similar desire for change. But in the cut and thrust of electoral politics, what did these high-sounding fancy words really mean in practice?

On one social occasion, Kanishka and I got down to discussing UP politics. He rattled out impressive statistical data on caste and community equations in the state, but you could easily sense this was the kind of knowledge that one acquires on the Internet. He couldn't, or so I sensed, have intimate knowledge of the local leaders of the Congress in each district of UP, the kind of personal information that makes a Mayawati or a Mulayam such a formidable opponent in the state. The roaring, rumbustious subaltern leaders of the Hindi belt can hardly be combated through an academic grasp of caste combinations.

The other member of Rahul Gandhi's A-Team was Sachin Rao. Like Kanishka, he, too, was foreign educated, having got an MBA in international business and strategy from the University of Michigan. He was deeply influenced by management guru C.K. Prahlad's 'Bottom of the